1.3 Battles of Saratoga

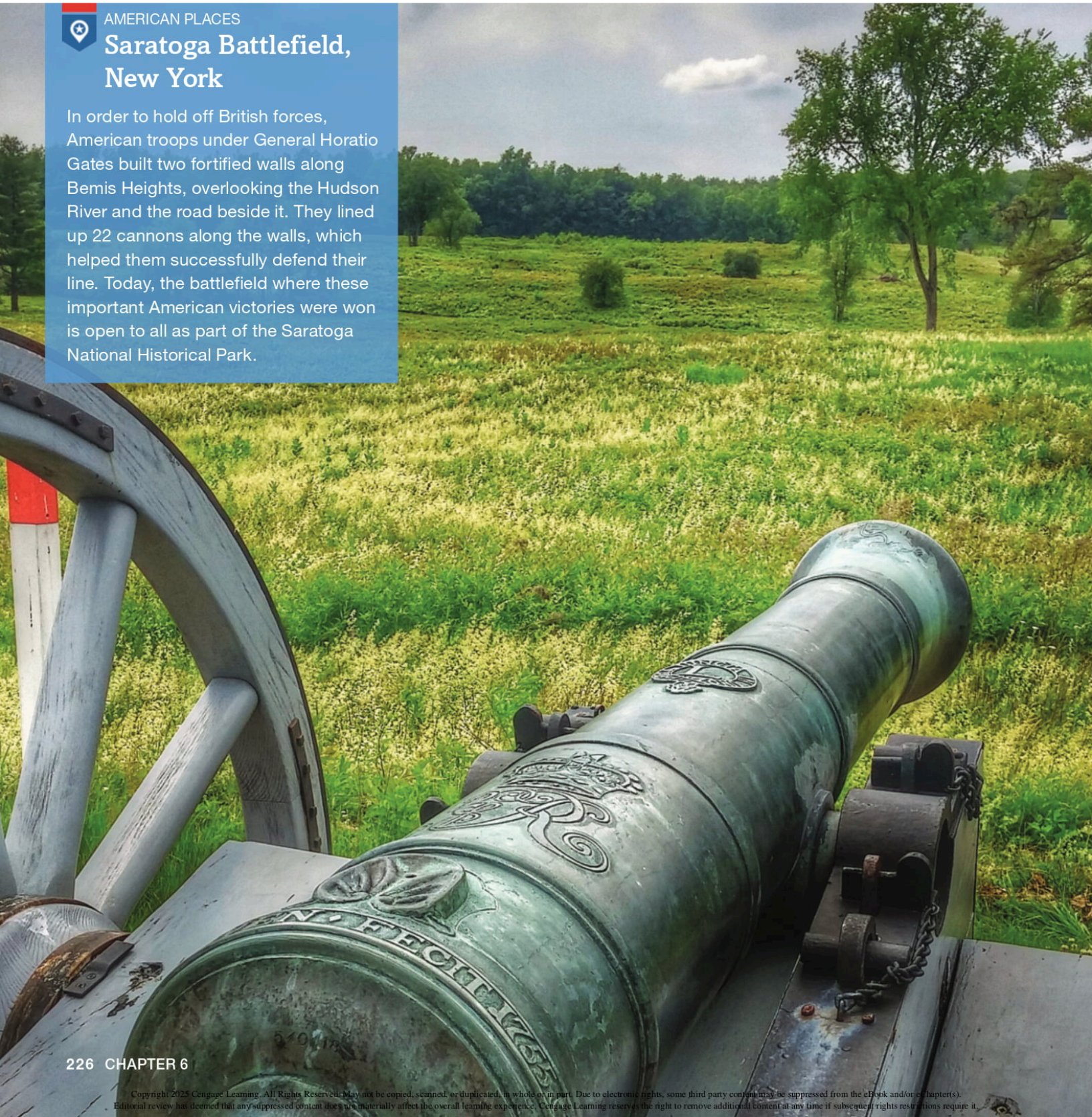
Sometimes things just don't go as planned. Unexpected events can derail even the best strategy—events like being hopelessly outnumbered, for example.

MAIN IDEA American planning and coordination, along with British miscalculation, led to Patriot victories at Saratoga and a turning point in the American Revolution.

AMERICAN PLACES

Saratoga Battlefield, New York

In order to hold off British forces, American troops under General Horatio Gates built two fortified walls along Bemis Heights, overlooking the Hudson River and the road beside it. They lined up 22 cannons along the walls, which helped them successfully defend their line. Today, the battlefield where these important American victories were won is open to all as part of the Saratoga National Historical Park.



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A TURNING POINT

As you have read, General Burgoyne found himself in a tricky situation as he moved south—without backup—toward Albany after his victory at Fort Ticonderoga. He expected to be joined by British troops moving north from New York, but that support never came.

Here's what happened: In September 1777, 12,000 members of the Continental Army under General Horatio Gates surrounded Burgoyne and his 5,800 men at Saratoga, New York. The Americans were well prepared for this clash. Gates and Polish military engineer Tadeusz Kościuszko (tah-DAY-oosh kos-CHOOS-ko) had overseen a plan to build up American **fortifications**, or structures built to protect a place from attack.

They had brought in reinforcements from other states as well, including the Light Horse Volunteers commanded by Colonel John Langdon. One of Langdon's men was Wentworth Cheswell, an African-American government official from Massachusetts. Though the British Army had been more welcoming of African-American volunteers, soldiers such as Cheswell had started to support the Patriot cause in larger numbers.

On September 19, 1777, the British and Continental armies clashed at what would later be known as the First Battle of Saratoga, also called the Battle of Freeman's Farm. Burgoyne failed to cross Gates's lines. The British struck at the Americans again on October 7, but General Benedict Arnold staged a strong American **counterattack**, or attack in response, in what would be known as the Second Battle of Saratoga. At this point, 20,000 American troops surrounded Burgoyne's men. Burgoyne had requested that General Howe send reinforcements, but, as you may recall, Howe and his troops were on their way to Philadelphia. Greatly outnumbered, Burgoyne surrendered at Saratoga on October 17.

An African-American Hero of the Revolution

Wentworth Cheswell is most often remembered today as one of the early African-American heroes of the American Revolution. As the town messenger of Newmarket, New Hampshire, Cheswell once had to ride all night to warn his community of an impending British invasion. He also served in the Continental Army with John Langdon's Light Horse Volunteers.

But this was just one facet of a man whose career in politics lasted nearly 50 years. His ancestry was part European, part African American. Formally educated in Byfield, Massachusetts, the 22-year-old Cheswell was elected in 1768 to his first political office—town constable of Newmarket. Over the course of his impressive career, he held other prominent posts, including justice of the peace for Rockingham County, New Hampshire.



A NEW ALLY

The **Battles of Saratoga** proved to be an important turning point in the American Revolution. As with the Battle of Trenton, the victories boosted Americans' morale and gave them hope that they could defeat a larger, well-established army.

Success at Saratoga also earned the Americans a valuable asset: an alliance with France. France was already supporting the United States with economic and military assistance, and these victories convinced the French government that the Americans could win the war. No longer feeling outmatched, the Americans now had military help from a wealthy nation, and they had experienced significant victories themselves.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why were the battles of Saratoga important for the Continental Army?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did an error in strategy affect the outcome of the Battles of Saratoga?
3. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** What problems did the Continental Army face at Saratoga, and what steps did it take to solve them?

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